had ‘tended to be lower than among men’. In 2014, the BJP-led NDA outscored the UPA by 19 per cent votes among men, but only by 9 per cent among women. In other words, in 2014, according to Roy and Sopariwala’s calculations, ‘If no women, only men had voted … NDA would have won by an enormous landslide with 376 seats [compared to its actual number of 336]. However, if no men, only women had voted, the NDA would have won 265 seats—which would have been seven seats short of the majority mark.’[30] Within five years, by 2019, this gender divide in voting underwent a seismic shift.

In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, according to the India Today–Axis My India post-poll survey, 46 per cent of women voted for the BJP, as opposed to 44 per cent of men. Women overwhelmingly supported Narendra Modi, according to this post-poll survey, the only one to accurately predict the election results. It was based on a sample size of 7,42,187 respondents and conducted in each of the 543 Lok Sabha seats (an average of around 1,366 respondents per seat). In contrast to the 46 per cent of women voters who said they voted for the BJP and its allies, 27 per cent said they had voted for the Congress and its allies and 27 per cent for other parties.[31]

Interestingly, it was in the less economically developed Hindi heartland states that the BJP-led NDA alliance had a net gender advantage, with more women voting for it than men: in UP, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Haryana and Uttarakhand. In more economically developed states, in sharp contrast, the BJP still had a gender disadvantage (see Table 17.1). The more developed a state, the less women are likely to vote for the BJP when compared to men (with the exception of Gujarat). Consider the states of Delhi, Karnataka and Maharashtra—all of which voted overwhelmingly for the BJP in 2019. In these three states, unlike the rest of the Hindi heartland, the BJP depended more on men than women voters: Delhi with 54 per cent women voters compared to 60 per cent men, Karnataka with 48 per cent women voters compared to 54 per cent men and Maharashtra with 50 per cent women voters compared to 52 per cent men voters. Moreover, at the national level, as many as 50 per cent women who mentioned their occupation as housewives voted for BJP+. This was double the 23 per cent of housewives who